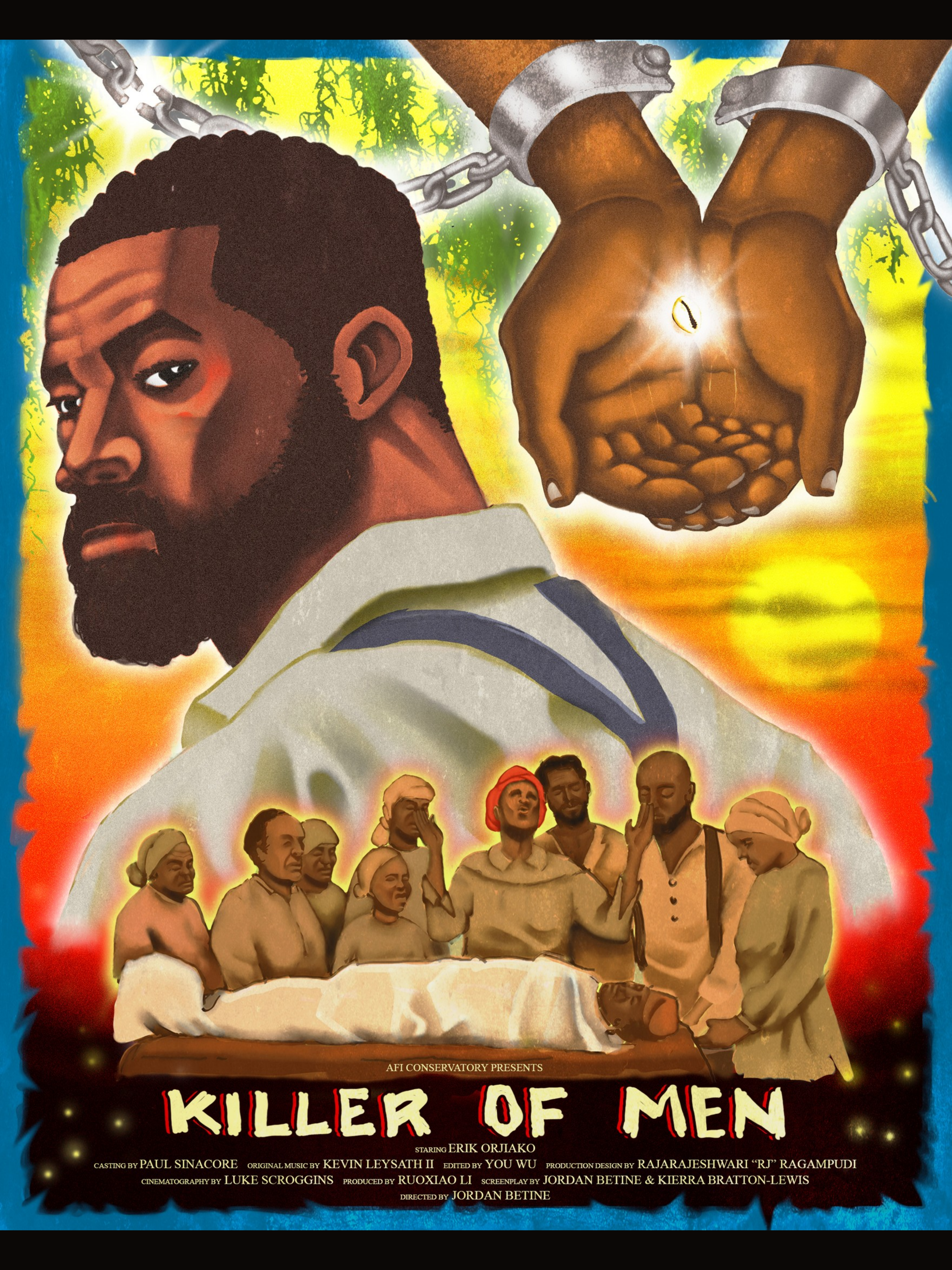




AFI CONSERVATORY PRESENTS

# KILLER OF MEN

STARRING ERIK ORJIAKO

CASTING BY PAUL SINACORE ORIGINAL MUSIC BY KEVIN LEYSATH II EDITED BY YOU WU PRODUCTION DESIGN BY RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI

CINEMATOGRAPHY BY LUKE SCROGGINS PRODUCED BY RUOXIAO LI SCREENPLAY BY JORDAN BETINE & KIERRA BRATTON-LEWIS

DIRECTED BY JORDAN BETINE





## LOGLINE

In 1834 South Carolina, an enslaved prizefighter survives by killing his own. Every victory buys him another night and costs a man his life. He walks in on that man's burial, held in the faith of their shared ancestors, and is forced to reckon with the man he was meant to become.

## SYNOPSIS

Mace fights because the alternative is the field, and then the ground. On a South Carolina plantation in 1834 his owner stages bouts against other enslaved men and takes the wagers; Mace has never lost, and every win buys him another season.

Then a fight ends in a death, and he follows the body to a burial held in secret in the Yoruba faith he was born to. The rites are for a man he killed. An elder tells him what he would have been across the water, and he sees, for the first time, what he has become.

# K I L L E R   O F   M E N

GENRE: HISTORICAL DRAMA, SOUTHERN GOTHIC

COUNTRY: UNITED STATES

SHOOTING LOCATION: CALIFORNIA

PRODUCTION YEAR: 2025

COMPLETION YEAR: 2026

LANGUAGE: ENGLISH (.SRT AVAILABLE: ENGLISH)

DURATION: 13 MINUTES

ASPECT RATIO: 2.39:1

FRAME RATE: 24 FPS

SHOOTING FORMAT: ALEXA 35 ARRIRAW

SOUND: 5.1, STEREO

## THE TEAM

WRITTEN & DIRECTED BY: JORDAN BETINE

PRODUCER: RUOXIAO LI

CINEMATOGRAPHER: LUKE SCROGGINS

PRODUCTION DESIGNER: RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI

EDITOR: YOU WU

## CAST

MACE | ERIK ORJIAKO

MASTER KENNER | ERIC PARGAC

KOJO | JAMAL DENNIS

KOJO'S MASTER | CASEY LONG

FRED | CHAUNDRE HALL-BROOMFIELD

ELDER | SANDRA MCDANIELS

GIRL | LOREN FENTON

SPECTATOR | DANIEL KASSAR

SPECTATOR | NIKITA KORSHUNOV

## RIGHTS

RIGHTS HOLDER: AFI CONSERVATORY

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## LINKS

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[WWW.KILLEROFMEN.COM](http://WWW.KILLEROFMEN.COM)

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# DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

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Growing up, I was always one of the youngest in my year, but my height made me one of the tallest in the class. I was often one of the biggest in the room. As I got older, I started noticing how my mere presence was often seen as either a point of praise or persecution. My physicality, tied so closely to my skin, made me seem more menacing, more dangerous than the other boys—even those bigger and stronger than I was. It's never anything overt, but small, incessant microaggressions. Death by a 1000 needles. It's a plight that's shaped me throughout my life, leaving me hyper-aware of myself in spaces. This experience, this reality, is tied to the plight of the Black man in America.

The concept of Mandingo fighting has always fascinated me. It's a strange, bastardized idea in media and literature. To me, it represents many things: the commercialization of sports and entertainment, the myth of Black-on-Black crime, the portrayal of savagery in history, and the media. It's always been used to showcase the "Black brute," but it has never been shown subjectively from the perspective of those involved. What are their lives like? What do they hold dear? What keeps a man going when he's put in a situation like that? Setting this film in slavery times, rather than in the present day or during the 1960s, allows me to examine the deep-rooted history of this aggression. Visually, I want the fight scenes to reflect the physical sports Black men often participate in—body slams, boxing, football tackles—to show history repeating itself through various forms of expression. By setting the story in the 1800s, I also had the chance to explore my heritage. With slavery still in full force and new enslaved people being brought in from Africa, I can examine the past in different ways. I want to delve into the spirituality of the enslaved at the time, capturing the mix of cultures, beliefs, and religions that slowly formed what we now know as Black culture.

Killer of Men is an expression of pain—absolute brutality and suffering. But it's also a story of resilience, culture, and spirituality. This story has kept me awake at night, terrified of what I'm putting on the screen. Killer of Men has been a grueling process—one that's forced me to question a lot of myself as a man and as a storyteller. This is my Oriki, my folktale, my poem. I won't shy away from telling difficult stories or giving a voice to the voiceless. I will honor my ancestors and my culture in everything I do.

# F I L M M A K E R S

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## WRITER-DIRECTOR | JORDAN BETINE



Jordan Betine is a Nigerian-American filmmaker raised between Lagos, Nigeria, and Ashburn, Virginia. He earned his undergraduate degree in film from Howard University. Jordan studied Directing at the American Film Institute, where he directed six short films across genres, including historical drama, social realism, and surrealist comedy. His thesis film, "Killer of Men," is a historical drama set in 1830s South Carolina about an enslaved man who is forced into underground prizefighting. His work explores power, identity, and the African diaspora.

## PRODUCER | RUOXIAO LI

Ruoxiao Li is a storyteller from China. A graduate of the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, she is currently pursuing a degree in Producing at the American Film Institute. She is mentored by Lianne Halfon, whose notable works include Juno and Ghost World.



## CINEMATOGRAPHER | LUKE SCROGGINS



Luke Scroggins studied theater under David Connelly at the North East School of the Arts in his home town of San Antonio and continued at Otterbein University School of Theatre, earning a BFA in Acting. Television credits include SWITCHED AT BIRTH, GENERAL HOSPITAL and DAYS OF OUR LIVES. After a period coordinating and editing for fashion clients, Scroggins joined the Dark Side and began working in camera. Recently he has moved into the narrative space as Utility on the independent feature FRESH KILLS and the limited series RZR. He made his cinematographer debut on the short films COSMIC BEACH and L'DIRECTOR



PRODUCTION DESIGNER | RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI



Rajarajeshwari "RJ" Ragampudi, is a recent graduate with a bachelor's degree in Architecture from India. She is recognized in her university for her undergraduate thesis, an in-depth research-based design project through the study of the films of the Indian film director, Satyajit Ray. Her experience as an Architect has helped her gain practical knowledge in spatial design, construction and project management. Along with this, she is also skilled in creative visualization with a stark interest in Film, enabling her to pursue an MFA degree in Production Design. She strives to design sets that are not only authentic to the setting but deeply character-driven, enhancing and punctuating key moments in the story.

EDITOR | YOU WU

You Wu is a working editor with four years of professional experience. He has worked on a range of short films across different genres, contributing as both an editor and in key roles such as DIT and sound designer. Several of the films he edited have been selected for major film festivals, including LA Shorts and the Avignon International Film Festival.



MACE | ERIK ORJIAKO

BILLED CAST

|               |                          |
|---------------|--------------------------|
| MACE          | ERIK ORJIAKO             |
| MASTER KENNER | ERIC PARGAC              |
| KOJO          | JAMAL DENNIS             |
| KOJO'S MASTER | CASEY LONG               |
| FRED          | CHAUNDRE HALL-BROOMFIELD |

|           |                  |
|-----------|------------------|
| ELDER     | SANDRA MCDANIELS |
| GIRL      | LOREN FENTON     |
| SPECTATOR | DANIEL KASSAR    |
| SPECTATOR | NIKITA KORSHUNOV |







# C A S T

|               |                          |
|---------------|--------------------------|
| MACE          | ERIK ORJIAKO             |
| MASTER KENNER | ERIC PARGAC              |
| KOJO          | JAMAL DENNIS             |
| KOJO'S MASTER | CASEY LONG               |
| FRED          | CHAUNDRE HALL-BROOMFIELD |
| ELDER         | SANDRA MCDANIELS         |
| GIRL          | LOREN FENTON             |
| SPECTATOR     | DANIEL KASSAR            |
| SPECTATOR     | NIKITA KORSHUNOV         |

|                           |                                                                              |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| WRITER-DIRECTOR           | JORDAN BETINE                                                                |
| SCREENPLAY                | JORDAN BETINE & KIERRA BRATTON-LEWIS                                         |
| PRODUCER                  | RUOXIAO LI                                                                   |
| CINEMATOGRAPHER           | LUKE SCROGGINS                                                               |
| PRODUCTION DESIGNER       | RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI                                                |
| EDITOR                    | YOU WU                                                                       |
| ORIGINAL MUSIC            | KEVIN LEYSATH II                                                             |
| CASTING                   | PAUL SINACORE                                                                |
| EXECUTIVE PRODUCERS       | YINGLI XIN<br>ZEJU ZHANG<br>OLAOLUWA OLUWASEUN OGUNSEYE<br>KAY ANN SCROGGINS |
| UNIT PRODUCTION MANAGER   | SHIRLEY SUI                                                                  |
| FIRST ASSISTANT DIRECTOR  | EDDY GUDAKOV                                                                 |
| SECOND ASSISTANT DIRECTOR | KEVIN PRESCOTT                                                               |
| COLORIST                  | WALTER VOLPATTO                                                              |
| STUNT COORDINATOR         | ZEDRIC HARRIS                                                                |
| STILL PHOTOGRAPHER        | JEDIDIAH WOODS                                                               |

|        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| EXTRAS | D'SHAE J BEASLEY<br>MEL HAMPTON<br>AYODEJI FATIGUN<br>CHARLES KIEMA<br>TYLER FISHER<br>NIKKIA DANIELLE MATTHEWS<br>OLAOLUWA OLUWASEUN OGUNSEYE<br>PATIENCE DOOSHIMA OHABUIKE<br>YOULANDA DAVIS<br>DANNY POTTER<br>RICARDO VARGAS<br>ROB MARK SADUSKI<br>GAGE PHILLIPS<br>ERIK SCILLEY<br>ANTHONY AROYAN |
|--------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|



# C R E W

|                               |            |                                                    |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------|------------|----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                               |            | CAMERA                                             | SET DRESSERS                          | NICOLE KUANG<br>SHIRLEY WU<br>JAHNVI GUPTA<br>NAOMI STEVENS<br>CHANEL KALINSKI<br>CORAL LOMELI<br>ADRIAN GONZALEZ                             |
| CAMERA OPERATOR               |            | DOMINIKA PODCZASKA                                 |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
| STEADICAM                     |            | DAE HYUN KIM                                       |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
| FIRST ASSISTANT CAMERA        |            | JULIA MAIXER                                       |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
| SECOND ASSISTANT CAMERA       |            | TRISTIAN IBARRA MARTIN                             |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
|                               | DIT        | KATE KEYING WU                                     | ART PAS                               | ROMAN RAYNES<br>CHERICE CARR<br>CHEN JING<br>JUE "JADE" LIN<br>ANDREW LEE                                                                     |
| STILL PHOTOGRAPHER            |            | JEDIDIAH WOODS                                     |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
| SECOND UNIT CAMERA            |            | REB RICHARD<br>ELIOT GRIGO                         | SCENIC PAINTER                        | MAYRA C. SAUCEDO                                                                                                                              |
|                               |            | PRODUCTION                                         | COSTUME, HAIR AND MAKEUP              |                                                                                                                                               |
| LINE PRODUCER                 |            | COLT KOZAL                                         | COSTUME DESIGNER                      | X. HILL                                                                                                                                       |
| SCRIPT SUPERVISORS            |            | LIBBY MCNEIL<br>ZHIYAN LIU                         | ASSISTANT COSTUME DESIGNERS           | ODESSA NEWMAN<br>JOLISA OSBORN-POLAKOFF                                                                                                       |
| PRODUCTION COORDINATOR        |            | JACK RUEFLI                                        | DEPARTMENT HEAD MAKEUP AND SFX MAKEUP | SHAWNEE CERKOWNIAK                                                                                                                            |
| 2ND SECOND ASSISTANT DIRECTOR |            | JAPHET E. VELAZQUEZ                                | KEY MAKEUP ARTIST                     | NEVE ANDREWS                                                                                                                                  |
|                               |            | ELECTRIC                                           | POST                                  |                                                                                                                                               |
|                               | GAFFER     | ADAM BIRCH                                         | ASSISTANT EDITOR                      | HAZEL YUNTONG DAI                                                                                                                             |
| BEST PERSON ELECTRIC          |            | CHANSOUL TAO                                       | COLORIST                              | WALTER VOLPATTO                                                                                                                               |
|                               | ELECTRIC   | JULES HOWARD<br>THOMAS LIAN<br>ERIC HE             | SAFETY AND SPECIAL EFFECTS            |                                                                                                                                               |
|                               |            | GRIP                                               | PYROTECHNIC DESIGNER                  | JOHN EGGETT                                                                                                                                   |
|                               | KEY GRIP   | WEILAND KURT                                       | FIRE SAFETY ADVISORS                  | WILLIAM MOORHEAD<br>KERRY YIM<br>TIM RUDDELL                                                                                                  |
| BEST PERSON GRIP              |            | EUGENE VISE                                        | SNAKE WRANGLER                        | AARON WELLS                                                                                                                                   |
|                               | DOLLY GRIP | ALEXANDER HAGEMAN                                  | ON-SET MEDIC                          | GREG LEVINE                                                                                                                                   |
| COMPANY GRIP                  |            | JASPER KHADJENOURI<br>HASAN IQBA<br>MATTHEW ROVETO | SUPPORT                               |                                                                                                                                               |
|                               |            | SOUND                                              | DRIVERS                               | ZHANYIN XIAO<br>CLAUDIO DEL PINO MERCADO<br>COLT KOZAL                                                                                        |
| PRODUCTION SOUND MIXER        |            | JACOB ELIETT                                       | OFFICE PRODUCTION ASSISTANTS          | EVELYN TANG<br>HONGYU AN<br>CLAUDIO DEL PINO MERCADO<br>TONGHAN "ANDI" TIAN                                                                   |
| BOOM OPERATOR                 |            | DAY WREN                                           | PRODUCTION ASSISTANTS                 | JUDE BRANDFORD-SACKEY<br>DAMINABO PETERSIDE<br>TYLER FISHER<br>NICHOLAS COLLINS<br>JOSHUA MONTREL<br>KAYODE OLADEJI<br>BIOLA OLATERU-OLAGBEGI |
|                               |            | ART                                                | CATERING                              | KYLIE ROTHFIELD                                                                                                                               |
| ART DIRECTORS                 |            | TREY WRIGHT<br>FERNANDO ACUNA                      |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |
| ASSISTANT ART DIRECTORS       |            | JAMES ROBERT<br>CYAN MIREILLE                      |                                       |                                                                                                                                               |



# T H A N K S

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THE FILMMAKERS WISH TO THANK

SHIQI SUKIA ZHANG  
XUANNING ZHANG  
DONGPO XU  
QING LIAO  
LINA HU  
PING GUO & BAOZHEN LING  
XIE LINCHEN  
WEIWEI XU  
Kuai YU  
XIAOMIN ZHANG  
XUANFANG GAO  
LIN YI  
MALLIK & PREETHI RAGAMPUDI  
SANTOS VELAZQUEZ & ANADELIS FIGUEROA  
DAWN AND J. MARTIN  
AKSHAY KUMAR  
PADMA CHITRAPU  
SRIRAM CHINTALAPATI  
SAIRAM TADIGADAPA  
SRINI TIPIRNENI  
RAGHURAM & KANCHAN DEVARAKONDA  
NELLA SUBRAMANIAM & SHAILA NELLAI  
PHILLIP BROOKS  
TRACEY B  
BYRON CHANG  
SALAAR KHAN  
YUHONG LAI & CHUNHUI WU  
CECIL GAO

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RUOXIAO LI, AFI PRODUCING FELLOW  
RAJARAJESHWARI RAGAMPUDI, AFI PRODUCTION DESIGN FELLOW  
LUKE SCROGGINS, AFI CINEMATOGRAPHY FELLOW  
JORDAN UWHUBETINE, AFI DIRECTING FELLOW  
YOU WU, AFI EDITING FELLOW

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